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REVIEW ARTICLE



Employability of international postgraduate taught students in the UK: a systematic literature review using PRISMA

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ABSTRACT

One-year postgraduate taught programmes in the UK attract global talent through high-quality education, yet the employability and career pathways of these students remain understudied despite their recognised vital economic and cultural contributions. Amid the UK's higher education financial crisis, marked by funding cuts, staff layoffs, rising costs, and reliance on international student recruitment, this study employs the PRISMA 2020 framework to systematically review literature (2014–2024) on international postgraduate taught student employability. Analysing 13 studies from Web of Science, Scopus, and Google Scholar, the findings reveal gaps in tailored sector-specific career and employability support, access to employment development opportunities and work-integrated learning practices, and culturally sensitive language support. The limited number of available studies highlights the need for further research, particularly in STEM-related subjects of study and among African and Indian Subcontinent students, to address systemic barriers and enhance employability support in a shifting academic and geopolitical landscape.

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SUSTAINABLE

DEVELOPMENT GOALS

SDG4: Quality Education

Introduction

Over the decades, employability research has intrigued countries such as Australia, Canada, the United States, the UK, and others, leading them to define employability skills and refine the existing frameworks and models as a part of their support for achieving microeconomic objectives (Alrifai & Raju, 2019). As reported by Universities UK (2023a), the postgraduate student population reached 372,500 by the academic year of 2022, marking a 23.8% increase from the previous year. This growth, particularly evident in non-EU postgraduate taught master's students, saw a 42.8% rise, totalling 303,375 students. However, there remains a gap in understanding how the employability journeys and career pathways of international postgraduate taught students (IPGTs) are being shaped, given the fact that they are a highly heterogeneous student cohort in the UK's higher education system (Jackson et al., 2023). Whilst the UK's postgraduate market is discrete and remains robust, the practical careers exercises and students' expectations largely reply on non-educational policy-making changes (Artess et al., 2014). The identified ongoing dilemma is that international postgraduate taught students (IPGTs) still struggle with the same challenges in securing employment, utilising professional student and counselling services, and accessing employability-related

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opportunities (Tao, 2023). While career counselling and guidance play a pivotal role in enhancing students' employability, alongside the developed efficacy demonstrating a positive correlation with their readiness for the workforce (Lau et al., 2020), there remains a critical gap in prioritising such support throughout the international student journey, necessitating coordinated national advocacy campaigns of fostering proactive engagement and behaviours. Yet, this is not surprising, as increasing research has demonstrated that the career prospects of enhancing employability and future marketability still function as the key drive for international students choosing to study abroad (Fakunle, 2021; Jackson et al., 2023; Zhao et al., 2022).

There is a growing research focus on graduate employability to ascertain if the surplus of talent has influenced a novel construction of IPGTs' employability (Tao, 2023). However, the key factors impacting their employability journeys, particularly within specific heterogeneous groups, are still sparse and vague (Nachatar Singh et al., 2023), and stakeholders' perspectives on IPGTs' employability are highly diverged (Zhao & Cox, 2022). Additionally, the relationship between internationalisation within Higher Education institutes and the enhancement of employability during study abroad for IPGTs is unclear and unresearched (Fakunle, 2021; Fakunle & Pirrie, 2020). While there is a considerable amount of current critical and systematic (literature) reviews in various aspects within employability research, ranging from investigating and facilitating the current employability skills (Fajaryati et al., 2020; Scandurra et al., 2023; Sokhanvar et al., 2021; Tushar & Sooraksa, 2023), measuring employability (Donald et al., 2024; Eimer & Bohndick, 2023; Neroorkar, 2022), synthesising employability from stakeholder's perspective (García-Álvarez et al., 2022; Murthy & Machet, 2021), and to the specific area regarding gauging the subject-related employability (Alharahsheh & Pius, 2021; Wang, 2023; Winberg et al., 2020). However, scant evidence can be found regarding endeavours in formulating SLRs in the employability-related discourse of IPGTs, wherein this group is well-recognised for its enormous social-cultural and economic impact on the UK (Universities UK, 2023b). To address the aforementioned gaps, this SLR endeavours to consolidate the existing knowledge by identifying the gaps and trends and proffering evidence and insights into the current research on the employability of IPGTs within the scope of the UK. It aims to address the following research questions (RQs):

- (1) What is the current understanding of the employability of IPGTs in the UK? Are there any discrepancies among different student cohorts or subjects of study?
- (2) What are the main challenges IPGTs encounter in developing their employability and enhancing career pathways during study abroad? Are there any specificities among different student cohorts?
- (3) How can we better support the employability of IPGTs during their studies?

Literature review

Definition of the international postgraduate taught student

Postgraduate (PG) education has expanded drastically in global scope, particularly in many Western countries where it has been sophisticatedly commercialised in the international market to attract international students from around the world. Whilst PG education has more than just a singular definition, it conventionally refers to Master's or Doctoral studies, or equivalent certificates and diplomas recognised by higher education bodies and governments, demonstrating a more demanding knowledge and in-depth understanding of the chosen subject or field of study (House, 2020). According to the Higher Education Commission (2012), PG study can be defined as "consisting of programmes that are more advanced than undergraduate study, usually undertaken by those who already hold undergraduate degrees. It is something of an umbrella term, encompassing a diverse array of provision – from short certificate courses to four-year PhD research projects, to professional doctorates studied largely in the workplace" (p.19). However, the definitional statements of

PG study differ greatly across international boundaries, especially concerning the formed terminology of the programme, length of study, learning or research structure, and subject of study.

PG study falls into two categories encompassing taught-based (e.g. MA, MSc MBA, MEng, LLM) and research-based (e.g. MPhil, MRes, PhD, DPhil) (Morgan, 2014). For the UK's postgraduate taught degree, the programme normally takes one year (full-time) to complete, and the learning outcomes are primarily assessed through submitted coursework, conducted exams, and a final independent research project or dissertation (House, 2020). Meanwhile in China, the Master's degree is equivalent to a UK PGT degree wherein it usually takes two to three years to accomplish, and the characteristics of a Chinese Master's degree involves a combination of coursework and research components, along with a final dissertation defence after completing a set number of research credit hours. Given the fact that postgraduate education has widened its participation and fair access, Morgan (2014) clarified that in countries such as the USA and Canada, postgraduate degrees are referred to as "graduate" degrees, with a Master's degree equivalent to a UK's PGT degree. Compared to a UK's PGT degree, USA's Master's degree typically lasts two years on average, with the first half of the Master's study focusing on the broader subject area and the later year delving into the expertise of study (Education USA, n.d.) whereas UK's taught Master's is often focused on specific areas from the start. In short, it is challenging to synthesise recognised graduate outcomes and employability-related issues based on the global diversity of Master's programmes and structure, concerning the discrepancies in measuring graduate outcomes, learning pedagogy, and the tenure of higher educations in different countries. Therefore, we only seek to propose the working definition of the international postgraduate taught student in this section, aligning with the overarching research aim & questions and the aimed research audience of the study.

According to QAA (2024), postgraduate taught (Masters) degrees prioritise more on the achievement of learning outcomes and intellectual attainment developed over the duration of study rather than the length of study. Meanwhile, international students, as well-known defined by OECD (2013), are "those students who left their country of origin and moved to another country for the purpose of the study ... international students may be defined as students who are not permanent or usual residents of their country of study or alternatively as students who obtained their prior education in a different country" (p. 314–315). Therefore, based on the discussions above, the working definition of IPGT in this study is proposed as a non-UK individual who cross the border and is enrolled in a postgraduate taught programme at a British higher education institution, typically holding a bachelor's or equivalent qualification and have chosen to pursue further academic studies in a specialised field or discipline at the postgraduate level in the UK".

International student employability

The topic of employability research has received significant attention in recent years, taking multiple stakeholders' perspectives into consideration (Hains-Wesson et al., 2023; Huang & Turner, 2018; Römogens et al., 2020). At the individual level, employability refers to the "propensity of students to obtain a job" (Harvey, 2001, p. 98) and to fulfil the attribute requirement set by potential employers during the recruitment process, indicating a various accumulated hard skill and transferable (soft) skill to be employability in the job market (Tomlinson, 2012). Yet, existing literature has critiqued the individual approach of defining employability as overly emphasised on the "supply-side" perspective wherein a skillset mismatch and expectations between students and employers would occur (Nikusekela, 2016). At the institutional level, employability is closely intertwined with higher education, industries, and social norms that shape international students' employability journeys while studying abroad (Harvey, 2001). Furthermore, the institutional approach to defining employability is closely linked to the indicator of employment outcomes, lacking engagement with the statutory professional practices of individuals, and the measurement to gauge employability from the organisational level tends to focus predominantly on short-term courses (Bridgstock & Jackson, 2019; Harvey, 2001).

Extensive research has explored the various domains and dimensions of the employability of international students (Jackson, 2024; Raby et al., 2023; Zhao et al., 2022; Zhao et al., 2024). For instance, Bennett et al. (2023) advocated the urgent need to distinguish the employability discussions between the global south and the global north, emphasising the importance of reframing and adjusting the employability agenda to account for career aspirations, flexible arrangements from stakeholders, and cultural differences. This aligns with the perception that investigating international student employability should include their demographic differences, interdisciplinary variations, different forms of international experiences, and diversity & equity, indicating the formulation of critical employability that intertwines with the development of a student's self and shapes their agency in comprehending and navigating employability pathways (Raby et al., 2023).

Trending conceptualisations of international student employability draw from Holmes (2013), focusing on exploring three competing definitional categories of employability categories: "possessive", "positioning", and "processual". The possession of skills is often focused on meeting demands from employers and industries. However, cautioned by Holmes (2013), that overly emphasising the development of various forms of skills would produce a "plethora" of skill lists that graduates should possess, which potentially could lead to "the increase numbers of explanatory elements with no theoretical gain" (p.546). The positioning approach is sometimes linked to how international students exercise their active agency in demonstrating awareness and strategies to develop employability (Fakunle, 2021). Labelled as the third perspective of the processual approach to defining employability, it portrays employability not as a fixed set of traits but as the capacity to recognise the significance concerning an individual's dynamic professional development (Holmes, 2013). The procedural approach, valued for assessing the employability of international students, was examined by Soltani and Tomlinson (2024), who took an in-depth glimpse of their daily experiences within the broader educational and social structure setting. The finding highlighted that the practical-based process of development has a significant impact on integrating international students into the organisational dynamics, encompassing adept navigation of academic conventions and norms and reflective practices as a viable strategy to enhance students' transition to the workforce (Soltani & Tomlinson, 2024). Additionally, Huang et al. (2014) found that while students at research-intensive UK universities favoured skill-based employability approaches, those at teaching-focused institutions leaned toward positional and processual strategies. Furthermore, the Graduate Capital Model (GCM) (Tomlinson, 2017) is another popular approach to define and refine the concept of international students' employability, aimed at addressing the challenges of graduates regarding their transitions into the labour market. Tomlinson's GCM compounded the labour economics elements from human capital theory and the adjustment from a sociological perspective (Wallis, 2021) wherein five forms of capitals are constructed including human capital (hard skills & knowledge), cultural capital (cultural knowledge, embodied behaviours, distinction, and symbolic value), social capital (networks, relationships, and connections), identity capital (personal identities and employability narratives), and psychological capital (resilience, self-efficacy, and adaptability). For instance, Dai and Pham (2024) adopted GCM as a theoretical framework to explore the dimensions of international students' employability and agency within the scope of each capital correspondingly. The competing findings highlighted the multifacetedly nuanced perceptions of how societal and environmental factors shaped students' employability journey.

Methodology

The Preferred Reporting Items for Systematic Reviews 2020 (PRISMA 2020) (Page et al., 2021) is adopted as guidelines to produce the study, with an internal protocol developed by the research team (Wang, Huang, WM, and Wu) to ensure methodological rigour (see Appendix 1). Whilst there still exists considerable variance in structuring and presenting systematic literature review (Fisch & Block, 2018), PRISMA 2020 proffers a reasonably standardised checklist, ensuring reducing variance in reporting and improving structural clarity wherein key information in SLR is presented

comprehensively and critically (Page et al., 2021). The PRISMA method has been regularly utilised in review papers, signifying an appropriate approach to collecting evidence-based sources that helps to ensure the quality of the review process and decision-making. In the scope of employability review articles, examples can be found, such as Abelha et al. (2020) and García-Álvarez et al. (2022), wherein both highlighted PRISMA's role in promoting transparency, reproducibility, and quality assurance through structured data synthesis. Additionally, this study also utilises the PRISMA Checklist (Page et al., 2021) (see Appendix 2) as an actionable framework to guide the review process.

Data source and search strategy

We systematically employed and subsequently manually searched three electronic databases, including Google Scholar (indexed articles), the Web of Science (WoS) (prioritising Journal Citation Report [JCR] articles), and Scopus (peer-reviewed articles), between the years of 2014 and 2024. These three databases have the most highly valued sources for employability research, wherein WoS and Scopus were selected for their comprehensive coverage of peer-reviewed employability research, while Google Scholar ensured the inclusivity of interdisciplinary studies or other literature types. The search of language was restricted to English only. The selected timeframe reflects the period wherein employability research has gained prominence, along with a more heightened focus on advocating graduate outcomes intricately associated with employability discourse, highlighted by government bodies, higher education institutes, industries, and students & graduates themselves. To ensure the research scope for more accurate and eligible studies, we have generated search strings for each database using Boolean operators and field codes (see Appendix 1). Two researchers (Wang & Wu) independently executed the searches to ensure consistency. By providing the complete research strings and filters (codes), we adhere to PRISMA's reproducibility standards, enabling future replication of our review process. This transparency also facilitates the critical appraisal of our methodology and ensures the comprehensiveness of the systematic literature synthesis.

Eligibility criteria

The selection of the literature to review in this SLR includes a set of criteria as follows:

- Publication databases: Google Scholar, Scopus, and Web of Science.
- Type of literature: To increase the integrity and enhance the sensibility analysis of this SLR, it covers peer-reviewed academic journal articles wherein conference proceedings, books and monographs, government reports, theoretical or conceptual-based articles, literature reviews, and grey literature are excluded in this research. Considering the nature of IPGT cohorts in the UK, published PhD theses within the scope of the UK with high research quality will also be considered.
- Time frame: 2014 to 2024
- Research target: international postgraduate taught students
- Study type: Articles that collected empirical data, regardless of qualitative, quantitative, or mixed methods.
- Type of outcome measures: The outcome of the selected articles should provide solid evidence of the employability-related discourse via assessment, evaluation, or identification of key challenges, opportunities, and implications for IPGTs or contribute to the broader understanding of the employability landscape for this cohort.

Data collection and quality assessment

In total, there are three strands within the data collection and quality assessment. The first strand involved the identification of the related articles from the three databases and the removal of the

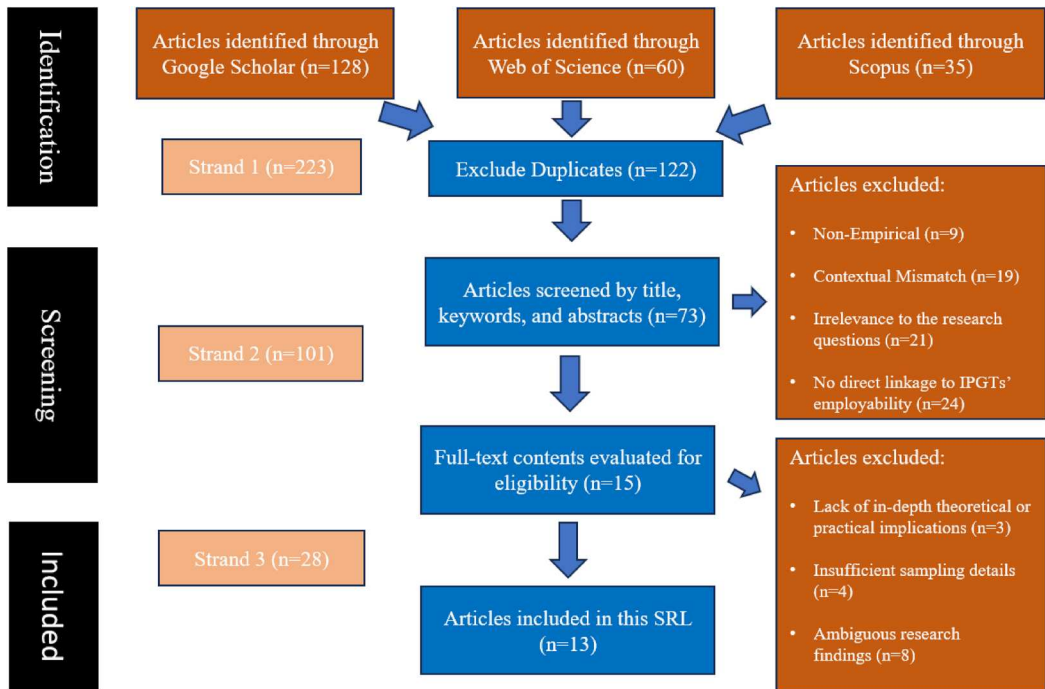
duplicates. Wang and Wu collected 223 literatures from the three main databases, encompassing Google Scholar ($n = 128$), Scopus ($n = 35$), and WoS ($n = 60$). A total number of 122 duplicates were removed afterward, leading to a reduction to 101 articles ready to be screened. No disagreement was achieved as we maintained clear guidance and communication of using the same proposed search strings. In the second strand, cautious reviews were conducted to examine the titles, keywords, and abstracts of 101 articles, wherein Wang, Wu, and WM narrowed the numbers down to 28 articles after excluding 73 pieces of literature. There were very few discrepancies in this stage as we elucidated a variety of exclusion reasons guided by the eligibility criteria, encompassing no direct linkage to the topic of employability, highly irrelevant to the research questions, contextual mismatch (other countries' HE contexts), and non-empirical.

In the third stand, four researchers reviewed the rest of the 28 articles independently, focusing on evaluating the full-text contents of the articles, especially focusing on whether the remaining articles have clear research findings, sampling details associated with IPGTs, and in-depth implications for IPGTs' employability theoretically and practically. We identified discrepancies in some articles. For instance, the recruited samples in Huang and Turner (2018) were not exclusively IPGTs, and Huang's (2020) study was a PhD thesis. However, after further evaluation, we retained both works for their valuable contributions. Huang and Turner (2018) included a substantial proportion of IPGTs (over 40%), and their findings offered meaningful insights closely tied to IPGT employability theoretically and practically. Meanwhile, Huang's (2020) work was also included for its student-centred perspective on how Chinese IPGTs strategically leverage their UK education trajectories to enhance employability, wherein it employed innovative photo-elicitation methods to capture rich and nuanced experiences. A further discrepancy among the four researchers concerned the target sample in Jackson et al.'s (2023) study, which focused on cohorts enrolled in a two-year MBA programme at a British university. However, we retained the article as its research aim specifically examined a three-day experiential learning residential rather than the broader two-year programme's impact on employability. Crucially, the findings highlighted significant theoretical and practical implications for the employability skills and employment outcomes of IPGT cohorts through these short-term, reflective, and simulation-based initiatives.

Eventually, 13 pieces of literature were selected. To align with PRISMA 2020 guidelines, we incorporated a systematic quality-assessment step for all 13 included studies. While no formal risk-of-bias tool was applied, each study's methodological rigour was evaluated based on predefined criteria, including clarity of research design, appropriateness of methods for addressing the stated aims, relevance of findings to IPGTs' employability, and transparency in reporting (e.g. sampling strategies, data collection). This approach ensured consistent judgment of study quality while prioritising this SLR's focus on employability perspectives. To further clarify the flow of the process, Figure 1 is developed as a flow diagram under the guidance of the PRISMA 2020 framework. All articles included in this SLR ($n = 13$) are labelled based on the retrieved databases (G = Google Scholar; S = Scopus; W = Web of Science), which are used to identify each one of the articles.

Data extraction, synthesis, and analysis

The remaining articles were further extracted and synthesised by the researchers to answer the proposed research questions in this SLR. To ensure the methodological rigour, we implemented an independent dual data extraction (Wang & Wu) was conducted wherein researchers cautiously extracted textual data. The team employed Microsoft Excel as the primary analytical tool to organise and cluster diverse elements from each study through an iterative coding process. This textual synthesis approach incorporated 14 key dimensions of ready for analysis: (1) year of publication; (2) journal of publication; (3) research targets in details; (4) location; (5) field of study; (6) methodology; (7) sample size; (8) theoretical or conceptual framework; (9) data collection and analysis; (10) findings and results; (11) discussions; (12) limitations, (13) implications, and (14) future studies (recommendations). This comprehensive synthesis method enabled a nuanced, multi-layered investigation of the literature while maintaining transparency in data handling and

Figure 1. Reporting Results for the Review (adopted from PRISMA 2020).

risk of bias assessments of each piece of literature, facilitating a more holistic understanding to address the proposed research questions and form a transparent visualisation of the findings in the next stage. We systematically identified and recorded missing elements from the selected literature, and the results showed that the majority of the selected studies clearly described their research objectives and data collection processes, alongside consistent findings, discussions, and implications. A few missing data were explicitly marked as blank entries in our Excel tracking system to maintain an accurate representation of the available evidence. Consistent with our pre-established internal protocol, studies containing these missing elements remained included in our systematic review, but the specific blank data fields were excluded from subsequent thematic analysis to ensure the integrity of our qualitative synthesis.

Further, it adopted a thematic analysis technique (Clarke & Braun, 2017), involving coding and categorising the extracted data into recurring themes, comparing patterns across different student cohorts and disciplines. Four authors conducted the analysis independently, especially focusing on how the emerged themes (factors) can respond to the proposed research questions, adhering closely to PRISMA 2020s key ethos of transparency and bias reduction as thematic analysis is ideal for PRISMA 2020 reviews as it flexibly identifies and synthesises key patterns across literature while ensuring transparency and reproducibility (Abelha et al., 2020; Page et al., 2021).

Moreover, to explore potential sources of heterogeneity, themes were systematically compared across subgroups (aligned with the 14 predefined components) to identify patterns and divergences. This approach accounted for better variability in study designs, target populations, and contextual factors within the selected literature. Further, effect measures were not applicable, as outcomes were synthesised thematically, and the recurring themes are presented in the result section. Discrepancies were resolved through consensus and continued discussions and meetings wherein all four authors were involved.

Strengths and limitations

This study follows PRISMA 2020 guidelines, employing a systematic multi-database search, independent identification, screening, and thematic analysis of recent empirical studies (2014–2024) to explore the existing understanding of IPGTs' employability and identify the challenges or systematic barriers. Although we intended to convey a broad dimension of international student employability into our SLR, the review criteria scope is constrained by its focus on IPGTs' employability within the context of the UK, due to the country's unique characteristics, including the structure of its post-graduate programmes, its immigration policies, and the significant economic contribution of IPGTs to the higher education sector and wider economy. Given the exploratory nature of this SLR, which aimed to identify, describe, and map recurring themes rather than assess their reliability for decision-making, a formal certainty assessment was not undertaken. This aligns with similar SLR under the guidance of PRISMA in the employability field (e.g. Abelha et al., 2020; García-Álvarez et al., 2022), as this study focuses more on conceptual enrichment rather than evidentiary grading, wherein we highlighted the variations in study quality and thematic consistency to guide the interpretations. Additionally, while we did not include a formal protocol registration, the quality of the studies included was assessed using predefined inclusion and exclusion criteria. These were informed by an internally developed internal protocol, aligning closely with the PRISMA 2020 checklist to ensure transparency and rigour. Moreover, the review process included multiple stages of identification, screening, quality appraisal, and thematic synthesis, all aimed at enhancing the reliability of our findings.

Results

This section reports the findings of 13 journal articles published on Google Scholar, WoS, and Scopus from 2014 to 2024. First of all, it reports the synthesised characteristics of the included articles encompassing codification of papers included in the SLR, frequency of publication of the studies in the review by year, and frequency of published journals. Secondly, it presents the analysed outcomes addressing each research question retrieved from the results of the thematic analysis outcomes accordingly.

Reporting the characteristics of the included studies

Codification of papers included in the systematic literature review

As the identified studies in this SLR are relatively small in quantity, Table 1 is developed to offer a concise overall visualisation of the literature. Each selected study is labelled and coded in alphabetical order by the authors, based on the retrieved database (G = Google Scholar; S = Scopus; W = Web of Science). The table also includes information encompassing the year of publication, article type, methodology, samples, countries and regions of the participants, and the subject of the study (participants). By doing so, it aligns with the guideline of PRISMA 2020 (Page et al., 2021) in generating a natural flow of operation, ensuring a transparent and concept-centred review process (Fisch & Block, 2018).

Trends & frequency of the publications per year

Figure 2 demonstrates the trends and frequency of the publications from 2014 to 2024, illustrating an increase in research attention to the employability of IPGT cohorts. Some authors claimed (e.g. G5; Niu et al., 2022) that Covid-19 has significantly impacted the landscape of higher education, prompting institutions and policymakers to reassess existing practices and prioritise to boost the graduate outcomes, reflecting the concerted effort to address the evolving careers and employability needs and challenges to attract international students.

Table 1. Codification of the identified studies in SLR.

Code	Reference	Article Type	Methodology	Samples	Countries & Regions	Subject of study
S1	Baker et al. (2014)	Research Article	Interviews	$n = 41$ (22 males and 19 females)	Africa, Asia, Europe, and North America	23 different disciplines including Fine Art, MBA, Environmental Science and Computer Science
G1	Cao and Henderson (2021)	Research Article	Diary-keeping Method	$n = 32$	China	Social Science
G2	Fakunle (2019)	PhD Thesis	Interviews & Document Analysis	$n = 19$ (4 males and 15 females)	Non-EU countries	Social & Political Science; Literatures, Languages & Cultures; Education; and Business
W1	Fakunle (2021)	Research Article	Interviews	$n = 19$	Non-EU countries	Humanities, Arts and Social Sciences
W2	Fakunle and Pirrie (2020)	Research Article	Interviews	$n = 19$	Non-EU countries	Humanities, Arts and Social Sciences
G3	Huang (2020)	PhD Thesis	Interviews	$n = 11$	China	Education, Business, and Engineering
G4	Huang and Turner (2018)	Research Article	Questionnaire	$n = 449$ (41.6% are current PGT students)	China	Business-related subjects, Accounting and Finance
S2	Igwe et al. (2020)	Research Article	Ethnographic approach (interviews, observations, and field notes)	$n = 45$	Asia & Africa	Business
S3	Jackson et al. (2023)	Research Article	Questionnaire	$n = 182$	Indian Subcontinent (India, Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal, and Sri Lanka)	MBA (Business School)
S4	Nachatar Singh et al. (2023)	Research Article	Interviews	$n = 15$	India	Arts and Humanities, Business and Law, Health and Education, Architecture
G5	Padgett and Donald (2023)	Research Article	Questionnaire & Quantitative Content Analysis	$n = 80$	Africa, Asia, and Europe	International Marketing Management
G6	Tao (2023)	Research Article	Interviews	$n = 9$ (5 males and 4 females)	China	Business, Biological engineering, Economics, Education, Art, and Law
W3	Zhao and Cox (2022)	Research Article	Questionnaire	$n = 148$ (89 are current PGT students)	China	Majority from Social Science

Frequency of published journals

Regarding the journals that are published on the topic of the employability of IPGTs, nine journals accepted the selected studies in this SLR (See [Figure 3](#)). It is noticeable that the Journal of Education and Work published the greatest number of studies in the chosen topic (G4, S3, W3).

Theories, models, and frameworks adopted in selected studies

A wide range of theories, models, and frameworks have been utilised to advance knowledge about employability by providing a theoretical foundation for empirical research, guiding research design and analysis, facilitating the integration of findings, and informing implications and future practice (See [Table 2](#)).

Figure 2. Frequency of publication of the studies in the review by year.

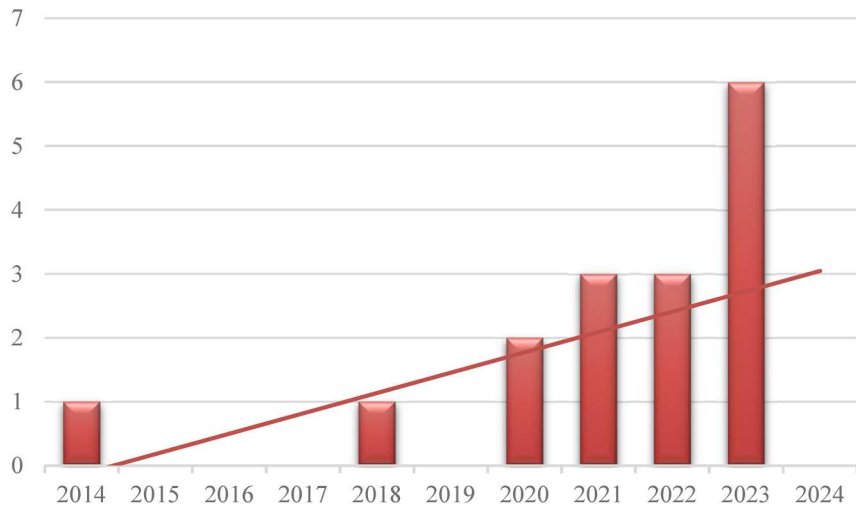


Figure 3. Frequency of published journals.



Table 2. Theories, models, and frameworks adopted in selected studies.

Theory	Framework	Model
Diary-keeping Behaviour Theory (G1)	Possession, Position, and Process Approach of Employability (G4)	The HEFCE Student Lifecycle Model (G2)
Social Position Theory (G3)	Personal Development Planning (PDP) Framework (S1)	CareerEDGE Model (S3)
Human Capital Theory (G5)	Symbolic Interactionist Framework (S4)	twenty-first Century Skills Model (W3)
Sustainable Career Theory (G5)		
Positional Conflict Theory (G6)		
Theory of Planned Behaviour (S2)		
The Agency Theory (W1)		
Theory of Reflective Thinking(W2)		

The existing employability of IPGTs embraced a variety of theories, frameworks, and models. These range from emphasising personal development and agency (W1, W2, S1, S4, G4) to explore the skill-centric theoretical approach to employability (G4; G5, S3, W3). In addition, understanding IPGTs' behaviours (G1, S2) is also linked with their long-term development and management of careers in ways that are economically, socially, and environmentally sustainable (G5). This indicates that short-term observations of pertained skills might not fully capture the complexity of IPGTs' employability. Therefore, taking a glimpse into various stages of the student journey within higher education could provide a more feasible and comprehensive understanding (G2). Furthermore, positioning-related approaches seem to be tangible theories and framework, grounded in current social contexts (G4), indicating explorations can be conducted to examines how conflicts over social positions influence employability outcomes (G6) or how an individual's social position influences their access to opportunities and resources related to employability (G3).

Presenting the analysed outcome to address research questions

This section presents the synthesised outcomes of the SLR, structured thematically to address the guiding research questions. The results are organised into key themes of each RQ, ensuring a reliable and transparent exploration of patterns relevant to the study's overarching objective.

RQ1: what is the current understanding of the employability of IPGTs in the UK? Are there any discrepancies among different student cohorts or subjects of study?

IPGTs are a group of highly job-focused students (S1), the finding from this SLR revealed that the current understanding of IPGTs' employability including the perceived value of a British postgraduate taught degree (G2; G6), garnered graduate employability capitals (G3; G4; G5), transferrable (soft) and hard skills (G2; G4; G5; W3; S3), international experiences (G1; G2; G4; W1), and support & initiative proffered by universities (G4; G6; S4; W1; W2; W3).

IPGTs benefit from personal development and career planning wherein the perceived transferable skills can be enhanced (S1). The significance of gaining additional and non-academic skills is to set oneself apart from the many other Master's degree holders (S1), signifying the broadened vision, confidence, and problem-solving skills via international study experiences are essential to improve employment opportunities (G5; G6). Whilst further concerning the employability of IPGTs, as stated in Paper G2, it is not a solely dependent construct wherein students' course-related subject knowledge, personal attainment, and social and cultural relationships should be also considered when it comes to the conceptualisation of their employability. From the perspectives of IPGTs, skills encompassing adaptability, analytical and problem-solving, assertiveness, critical thinking, (English) language skills, time management, social and cultural awareness, and respecting for diversity are the top list skills mapping their employability journey (G3; W3). Similarly, Paper S3 verified for IPGTs, especially of those who are undertaking MBA programmes, self-confidence, self-reflection, and a decent level of emotional intelligence (being empathetic) were found to have a significant relationship with their employment outcomes, which is slightly different from general IPGTs' essential employability skillset. This might draw from the nature of MBA studies which require students to apply their previous experiences on reflecting how their personal traits, behaviours, and performance shape the individual professional development. Different from MBA IPGTs, students from Business-related subjects are particularly concerned with language skills and sense of belongings (G3; S2). Moreover, a substantial body of literature concerning student employability across various disciplines, including social science, humanities, and business background (G1; G4; G5; W1, W2, W3, S2). However, IPGTs in STEM-related fields, such as engineering (G3; G6) and computer science (S1), observed a notable absence of explicit illustrations and discussion regarding student employability from these subjects. Similar circumstances are noticed among student cohorts from subjects including art (G6; W1; W2), law (G6; S4), architecture (S4), and education (S4; G6). Such

observations suggest the need for more nuanced considerations regarding the employability of students across different subject areas.

Graduate capitals (Tomlinson, 2017) have been adopted theoretically or served as guidelines to investigate the employability of IPGTs in several publications (G3; G4; G5). Findings from Paper G3 reveal that IPGTs can cultivate various forms of capital during their one-year study abroad. Career-building skills, developed from international experience, were reckoned as a most important part of human capital and can assist students' transition to the target labour market (G3). This perspective echoes the empirically informed strategy, serving as their obtained human capital, that IPGTs utilised to navigate themselves for securing potential employment (G5). In Paper G4, the authors suggested that British universities should consider the diverse support for international student cohorts, advocating for them to see beyond their studies and recognise the broader significance of the courses in fostering critical self-awareness and cultivating cultural capital. In this regard, to develop cultural capital, some IPGTs emphasised that the narrative of the international experiences in the UK outweigh more to the postgraduate degree itself in developing cross-cultural understanding and sensibility. Whilst Paper S1 indicated that developed self-awareness can enable IPGTs to express a desire for support to clarify their thoughts, this can be further linked to one of the graduate employability capitals – psychological and identify capital wherein IPGTs can cope with challenges and better position themselves in the target labour market. In this regard, Paper G3 verified that IPGTs can garner identity capital via self-construction of employability identity and psychological capitals via overcoming academic, career, and life challenges to be resilient and adaptable. Concerning the social capital, IPGTs tend to exploit the university resource to build relationships and connections (e.g. careers and counselling service) to facilitate their access to the labour market (G3), as career counselling has been one of the key proactive career behaviours of student cohorts to enhance personal confidence in career decision upon graduation (Lau et al., 2020; Strauss et al., 2012).

International experience is reported to be linked to IPGTs' employability (G1; G4). Paper G1 reflected the one-year journey of IPGTs in the UK, suggesting that employability-related activities such as personal travel, academic engagement, and dealing with emergencies can enhance students' employability management. This is in alignment with the finding from Paper G4 that international travel, volunteering, internships, and making friends with local students can broaden their perspectives, foster cultural sensitivity, and improve adaptability, all of which are highly valued by employers in today's globalised workforce. Additionally, engaging in international activities often requires IPGTs to navigate unfamiliar environments, communicate effectively across cultural boundaries, and solve problems creatively, further honing their professional skills. Therefore, the evidence presented in Papers G1 and G4 underpinned the significant correlation between international experience and the enhancement of IPGTs' employability prospects. This echoes the finding from Paper W1 that IPGTs can strategically develop their employability via their international experiences inside and outside of the university, underpinning an under-researched area of how international experiences contribute to students' employability agenda.

Undoubtedly, a UK PGT degree offers significant rewards, with international academic and cultural experiences enhancing graduates' employability and career readiness (G2; G4; G6), as the one-year structure provides a cost and time advantage over longer programmes in countries like the US and Canada (G6). In addition, joint ventures and multinational (international) corporates in a global scope also prefer students who position an international qualification wherein their perceived adaptability and soft currencies via international experiences are valued (G6). Alongside how IPGTs perceive the value of completing a master's degree in the UK, their employability is also tied closely to the support and initiatives proffered by their universities such as careers service (G6; S4; W1; W3), employment development opportunities (W1; W2), and experiential learning initiative (S3).

The competing finding of this study resolves the discrepancies in the understanding of employability among different IPGT cohorts. For Chinese IPGTs, a British master's degree is no longer as a competitive "hard currency" due to the massified enrolment of overseas students and the swelling

of graduate returnees (G3; G6). Whilst they value the enhanced educational status quo of receiving a British master's degree, students from China normally expect higher graduate outcomes (G3). However, Paper G6 identified that a master's degree seems less likely to their employability. Instead, their developed transferable skills (soft currency) during their international experience can, to some extent, contribute to the well-rounded quality, signposting their potential marketability to employers (G6). This is similar to the finding that the capacity to interpret and explain the skills learned in English into Mandarin matters a lot for Chinese IPGTs, especially for those who intend to go back to China to secure employment after their studies (W3). Although completing a British master's degree is a great life achievement, serving as a door-knocker for potential job interviews, it is commonly recognised among Chinese IPGTs that a comparable course in China is more valued by Chinese employers from state-owned companies (G3; G6).

For Indian IPGTs, their employability is more likely associated with the UK's job market condition and immigration policy (S4), wherein a sophisticated interplay between migration and education policies is pinpointed, suggesting a two-step migration complexity (securing employment and then obtaining permanent residency) is established as a trending phenomenon among this cohort in host countries (Hawthorne, 2014). Further, Paper S3 identified that the employability of IPGTs from the Indian Subcontinent is extremely associated with their narratives on return on investment and whether working opportunities and employability skills enhancement can be developed. Compared to the career-focused Indian subcontinent cohort, the employability skills of other Asian students from China, Hong Kong (SAR), Thailand, Malaysia, and Vietnam are more attached to their England language proficiency, cross-cultural understanding, integration of their international experiences and sense of belonging in a foreign country during their studies (S2).

RQ2: what are the main challenges that IPGTs face in developing their employability and enhancing career pathways during study in the UK? Are there any specificities among different student cohorts?

To comprehensively address the key challenges encountered by IPGTs in the UK, we cautiously examined the literature review and findings sections, with particular emphasis on the discussion sections. In doing so, we aimed to synthesise the authors' efforts to contextualise their findings within the framework of existing scholarly sources. Eventually, in addition to the current understanding of the employability discourse of IPGTs, there exists a mismatch in how to produce well-rounded and competitive graduates within the global agenda of internationalisation. This phenomenon potentially augments the institution's appeal to a broader spectrum of students from the global talent pool (W2). Whilst the enhancement of IPGTs' employability is mediated by various complex factors, both individual and institutional (W1), it is imperative to critically reflect on the persisting issues underlying inherent to the employability journeys and consider how existing challenges can be properly managed to amplify the opportunities for IPGT cohorts.

The findings pinpointed an ongoing and underestimated issue within higher education institutes in the UK, revealing a deficiency in tailored careers and counselling services and relevant employability support and assistance to IPGTs (G2; G6; S4; W2; W3). In Paper W2, it argued that career service within the university does not address specific employment and career challenges faced by IPGTs, such as career development and management, industry-specific guide on career materials, building tangible networks to industry professionals, goal setting, and assisting job relocation to host, home or third countries. This echoes the finding from Paper W3 and Paper S4 that career service lacks familiarity with international job market requirements, with the majority of services geared towards IPGTs being UK-centric. As Chen and D'Cruz (2023) argue, international students often face unique sociocultural and structural challenges that generalised career guidance and counselling services may overlook. Furthermore, evidence additionally highlighted that the knowledge scope of career practitioners within universities is not adequate enough and not reflective of dealing with the needs and unique circumstances of IPGTs (S4). It is noticeable that career support and initiatives within universities, such as building career information websites, creating social media channels for

better engagement, and training faculty specialists and careers & employability consultants for advice guidance and advice, are beneficial for student cohorts. However, underpinned by a competing finding (G6), albeit diverse and multiple career service lines are proffered, a disproportionate emphasis is placed on a select few mainstream disciplines that are perceived to be more conducive to employment support. Consequently, the majority of job opportunities are concentrated within the broader domain of business-related fields, thereby overlooking the employment prospects of students studying disciplines such as education and arts. Furthermore, most participants in the study (G2) recognised the importance of utilising the careers service. However, their feedback revealed that the career assistance provided did not sufficiently address job applications in specific areas, and the generic career-related emails from the Careers Service were not particularly helpful.

The lack of Employment Development Opportunities (EDOs) and Work-Integrated Learning (WIL) also exacerbated the dissatisfaction among IPGTs in the UK (S4; W1; W3). This might stem from the identified insufficient tailored employment assistance (G6; W3), limited internship opportunities for postgraduate taught students (S4), and biased hiring perceptions among employers, compounded by government policy implications (S4). Whilst the UK's educational system offers a fast-track route for gaining a postgraduate degree, its structure and timeline constrain employment opportunities for those IPGTs (W3). As noted by several participants (W3), the course is overly focused on academic content studies wherein limited practical and technical elements or internships could be involved, hindering the development of their employability skills (W3). Despite a considerable number of IPGTs being aware of the university's assistance in securing internships and offering on-campus student workers positions, and obtaining embedded optional industrial placement, it seems IPGTs still encounter challenges in fully engaging with these opportunities due to cultural differences, language barriers, and unfamiliarity with local job search processes, contributing to the relatively low participation rates in initiatives (G6).

On the other hand, based on the diary-keeping findings from Paper S1, there is an increasing awareness among IPGTs in better engaging with various opportunities and activities on campus. However, some of them might feel overwhelmed when entering into a new environment whilst pursuing a postgraduate taught degree, particularly in managing the influx of information regarding academic and professional development. This highlights the need to allow leeway for them to have self-reflection and career planning efforts (S1). The aforementioned perception verified that the low participation in WIL-related internships of IPGTs, due to the dominant focus on acquiring qualifications as the enhancement of their human capital, resulted in limited time for other experiences to develop their employability (S4). At the institutional level, concerns are raised by several respondents that accessing internship opportunities is challenging for international students in the United Kingdom due to insufficient guidance and dissemination of work placement information throughout the education institutes and universities.

English language deficiency has been reported as one of the top challenges that IPGTs are facing in terms of how-to better bridge cultural differences, fit in the academic environment, and seek potential employment opportunities to enhance their employability (G2; G4; S2). Whilst university academic support plays a crucial role in developing student employability, participants in Paper S2 observed that certain academic staff overlooked the fact that not all international students possess the same level of English language proficiency as domestic students. IPGTs adhere to the "session-holiday-deadline" model of their international study experience (G1), wherein improvement of language skills has been rated as one of the primary rationales for choosing to study abroad, especially for those who are identified as monolingual cohorts (G2). Furthermore, IPGTs encounter difficulties due to the unfamiliarity of both academic and social environments within the host countries and institutions (S4), supporting the significance of supporting the accumulation of cultural and linguistic capitals prior to arrival (G2). Interestingly, as clarified in Paper G2, even some international student cohorts with historical ties to the UK, where English is generally considered

their first language, may not experience smooth academic progression in their academic journey, posing potential challenges for academic support provision.

This study exemplifies the challenges that vary among different cohorts of IPGTs. For Indian IPGTs, it seems the academic and social adjustment concerns appear to impede their employability development (S4). To be specific, their employability journey development would be hindered due to the limited internship opportunities, visa regulation, existing biased perspectives from employers during the recruitment process, and sparse cultural-sensible career services proffered within the universities (S4). Compared to other students' cohorts, Indian PGTs seem more proactive in engaging with career services, yet they still suffer from limited valuable career support within the universities, wherein the tailored specialist advice, career guidance, and assistance to build a professional portfolio are missing (S4). Whilst Indian and Nigerian IPGTs are considering English as their first language, it is interesting to see their perceptions indicating that scant attention was given to non-native English-speaking students from countries with historical ties to the UK (S4). Despite Nigeria's significant increase in student numbers in recent years, making it the third-largest student cohort in the UK (Universities UK, 2023a), scant evidence is found investigating the employability-related issues and challenges of this cohort.

Different from Indian IPGTs, Paper G4 found that Chinese students were more concerned about language deficiency and culture integration. This cohort seems less self-sufficient in reflecting on the cultural discrepancies and understanding how to secure relevant support and opportunities to boost their employability. This differs from Indian students, as they are highly employment-centred, focusing on securing employment in the job market of the UK after graduation (S4). The perception resonates with the Chinese students in the research (S2) that England language proficiency is a critical concern during their postgraduate studies when it comes to communicating with students and staff from different backgrounds. In addition, Chinese students also express concerns regarding the timing of recruitment rounds in China conflicting with the schedule of their master's programmes in the UK (W3). China's recruitment process revolves around two main seasons: the spring recruitment cycle (March–May) and the autumn recruitment cycle (September–December). Whilst having teaching classes and academic activities to join thus dismissing the Spring hiring period, students often do not complete their dissertation projects until September, leaving them with limited time for job applications and interview preparations. Additionally, they do not receive their certificates until December or January, which hampers them from providing documents to sign contracts with employers (W3). With an increasing number of Chinese students returning to their home country seeking jobs, some respondents also indicate that there are insufficient resources for them to navigate career paths in China from the UK's universities (W3). Additionally, although certain employers may reach out to career services at UK universities for co-hosting career-related events, it seems the information is not transparent as students are relying on Chinese job-seeking websites and sources (W3).

RQ3: how can we better support the employability of IPGTs during their studies in the UK?

Supporting the employability of IPGTs is believed to be a process that intertwines student actions and the joint efforts within universities (G6). From the institutional level, there is an increasing trend in embedding employability-related concepts into modules as a curriculum-based intervention, short-term programmes, and employment opportunities into the one-year postgraduate taught course. Highlighted in Paper S3, a 3-day experiential residential programme is embedded into an MBA course, aiming to enhance the employability skills of IPGTs. The outdoor group work and various sources of reflection sessions of this programme were reported to significantly boost the self-confidence, self-awareness, teamwork, critical thinking, negotiation skills, and leadership of those students, especially for those from the Indian subcontinent area (S3). Apart from the enhancement of employability skills, this initiative also develops emotional intelligence and cross-cultural understanding both at the personal and professional levels, wherein these elements are beneficial for their long-term employment (S3). Different from the short-term programme as academic

intervention, new learning pedagogy initiatives such as Personal Development Planning (PDP) are embedded into the academic curriculum (S1). PDP refers to a systematic and guided procedure pursued by a learner to contemplate their learning, performance, and/or accomplishments, and to strategize for their personal, educational, and career advancement wherein the finding indicated that IPGTs are in general lack awareness of proactivity and initiatives in self-reflecting the challenges and opportunities during their one-year study (S1). It was reported that the utilisation of the PDP approach can enhance employability-related transferable skills, lifelong learning, and self-awareness (S1). In addition, integrating professional development and employability into the module is not new in the UK's higher education. Examples can be found in Paper G5 that a professional module entitled "The Global Marketing Professional Module" was specifically designed to enhance the employability of IPGTs majoring in International Marketing Management, engraving the rationale to "ensure that students understand the professional competencies required for non-linear graduate careers before considering career thinking and planning elements" (p.6). After two waves of questionnaires, the encouraging finding manifested the competing result that students have enhanced their human capital (confidence, CV development, workplace knowledge), social capital (networking), cultural capital, identify capital (proactive career ownership), and psychosocial capital (optimism and self-efficacy). However, it's worth noting that the scope of this improvement is limited to a specific programme within a single university. Therefore, it remains unclear whether similar results could be replicated across different programmes or institutions. Further research and exploration are needed to ascertain the generalizability and sustainability of these findings beyond the confines of this particular context.

IPGTs found that the limited WIL experiences within a one-year study would hinder their employability development and EDOs, the alternatives such as secure volunteering jobs and part-time casual employment outside of the university can to some extent enhance their social and cultural skills (W2). This echoes the implication from the findings of Paper S3 and G6, albeit the developed employability-related skills inside the university, it is also necessary to develop a more accessible system that better helps them to navigate university resources, guides them to articulate what they have learned in the classroom to the potential employers to overcome the lethargy and lack of working experiences exposure whilst study abroad. Therefore, it is suggested to extend the scope of EDOs in a more institutional approach to enhance the experiences of IPGTs (W2). In addition, it is suggested that universities should increase the amount of lecture time to increase the accessibility for students to explore the linkage of real-world experience, professional development, and subject knowledge (G5).

Insufficient and lack of tailored career service has been pinpointed as a critical challenge for IPGTs to develop employability during their one-year study in British universities (G3; G6; S4; W2; W3), indicating the real-world dilemma revolving around reconciling the benefits derived from career services with actions that truly enhance one's employability in the future workforce (W3). Results in the research (S4) indicate that students encounter difficulties in fully benefiting from the career support available at their universities, and it is necessary to customise the service to offer specialised advice, guidance, and assistance tailored to students' needs to assist in addressing their employability obstacles. Apart from enhancing the diversified needs for IPGTs, findings are also concerned with the promotion of the services from the career department, albeit the acknowledged value for students to kick off their career journeys, which is extremely patronised and underutilised by IPGTs (S1). Whilst the majority of the IPGTs in the study (G2) acknowledged the general positive side of using careers service, it is recommended that it is necessary to link the career opportunities to other students' home countries by collaborating with employers from different countries and tailored their service more closely to students' subject of studies. Regardless, as international qualifications no longer guarantee tangible employment (G6), it is essential to rethink the approaches and methods that are more inclusively tailored to enhance the career pathways and employment outcomes for IPGTs (G3; S3).

Apart from proffering tailored careers service, more EDOs & WILs opportunities, employability-related curriculum intervention, and short-term programmes to support IPGTs. Authors in this SLR also contend various forms of support such as rethinking insert structured industrial placement or insight days within the one-year course (S3) and revisiting the existing teaching and learning activities and methods in business schools affect students' sense of belonging, skill acquisition, and career development while assessing factors that engage or disengage students via response educational approach and theory of planned behaviours (S2). Whilst disruption caused by the pandemic reshaped the landscape of higher education by moving education delivery online or hybrid, it is also significant to reconsider to broader concept of internalised academic structure, richer content under an internationalisation agenda, and the corresponding teaching mode, fostering more satisfactory international experiences, a sense of belongings, integration, and engagement (S2; W1). The results of the synthesis of the support from British universities raised an essential account for developing more structural and inclusive approaches to developing IPGTs' employability. This could be potentially achieved via embedding employability skills into the academic curriculum (S3), developing more tailored career assistance (S4), creating extra-curricular programmes to boost professional development (G5; S3), and exploring the impact of background on employability from various student cohorts' expectations and concerns (G3).

Discussion

This SLR seeks to explore three critical issues encompassing the current understanding of IPGTs' employability, the challenges they face in developing employability during their studies, and the available support mechanisms, as well as how to better support their employability journeys. Underpinned by The UPP Foundation (2022), there is an urgent need to enhance the university experiences of international students by accelerating employability support to a more structural and systematic level. This could include increasing opportunities for graduates, fostering inter-sectoral collaborations to access international career perspectives, gaining governmental endorsement for employer education initiatives, and enhancing the accessibility of student and career services (*ibid*). Whilst the employability narrative in the UK is closely measured by the graduate outcomes, the current Higher Education survey excluded the data on international students due to the enacted strategies aimed at reducing the financial burdens, prioritising resources and efforts towards UK-domiciled graduates, and mitigating the potential impact on data usability (HESA, 2021). As the measurement and approaches to monitor the employability and graduate outcomes of IPGTs remain unknown, it becomes imperative to address this gap to comprehensively understand and effectively assist IPGTs in overcoming challenges. This involves gaining insights into the specific barriers, opportunities, and support mechanisms that influence IPGTs' employability while also taking into account the impact of the COVID-19 pandemic.

The concept of employability encompasses a multifaceted discourse that extends beyond the mere measurement by proposed skillsets from the employers' perceptions, contributing to direct employment outcomes (Singh & Fan, 2021). It also necessitates considerations of support by universities, especially for IPGT cohorts (G4; G6; S4; W1; W2; W3). Overreliance on initiatives and support on a singular stakeholder may lead to a narrow perspective of employability, associating it solely with employment issues wherein intrinsic capacities (what students can offer) would be considerably shifted to extrinsic demands of what employers want (Gedye & Beaumont, 2018), overlooking the inherent complexity of employability as a holistic construct, calling for more nuanced examination among various stakeholders, educational institutions, and broader socio-economic contexts (W2; W3).

Existing research on defining employability has primarily focused on the supply-side approach, emphasising employability skillsets and individual characteristics that align with the espoused needs of employers (Winterton & Turner, 2019), neglecting the processual and positioning aspects of how employability could be understood (Holmes, 2013). Whilst there is no one-size-fits-all approach to developing employability skills for IPGTs (S3), the current understanding of the employability of IPGTs remains dominantly in skills supply-side conceptualisations (G2; G4; G5; W3; S3; S4).

This perspective advocates for the development of various characteristics to make individuals more employable. Moreover, Römgens et al. (2020) identified the overlapping dimensions of employability skills between higher education and the workplace, suggesting more leeway for taking both components into account when it comes to refining the employability skillset in the future. However, this narrative shifts the focus on developing overall capacities to be employable to a more narrow focus on garnered specific employability skills (Holmes, 2013) that is considered as a “hollowed out” orthodoxy approach (McQuaid & Lindsay, 2013, p. 205), neglecting the fact that professional development requires both students’ proactivity and assistance from universities (G6). Additionally, this echoes the competing notion that employability also needs to be considered critically from the demand side of various industries factors (De Grip et al., 2004), suggesting to take account of different stakeholders’ perceptions (De Grip et al., 2004) and broadened the current understanding of employability that is utilised by higher education and policymakers (W1).

Apart from the identified evidence of insufficient employment assistance and limited tailored career service proffered to the IPGT cohort in the UK (G2; G6; S4; W2; W3), extensive research showcased the similar challenges faced by international (postgraduate) students in different countries such as Australia (Hains-Wesson et al., 2023; Nachatar Singh, 2023; Singh & Fan, 2021), USA (Niu et al., 2022), and China (Guan, 2023). Given the fact that employability serves as one of the goals of studying abroad, the existing mismatch of the actual outcomes from the master’s study and the perceived employability development shouldn’t necessarily be deemed problematic (W3). However, low engagement with career services and limited accessibility of the university resources within higher education of international students reflect a critical issue of insufficiency in developing internationalisation (G3; W3). Alternately, as suggested by Donald et al. (2018), students can also rely on their lecturers to work as career mentors for connecting specialised experts or industrial professionals, admitting the fact the career service (department) might struggle with insufficient resources & funding, staff shortage, and increased demands from student cohorts, especially in the post-pandemic period (Donald et al., 2022). The tenor of international students’ incapacities in their engagement with careers service also echoes the findings from Kenyon and Rowan-Kenyon (2014). That is, beyond enhancing the professional qualifications of career counselling staff, institutions must establish global partnerships to create tangible employment pathways and extend their career support mission outside of the campus (Kenyon & Rowan-Kenyon, 2014), as effective career guidance requires a multifaceted approach, such as examination of the training needs and experiences of graduates, students’ involvement in co-creating and evaluation of career-related guideline, as well as a coordinated series of interventions operating at both individual and institutional levels (Chen & D’Cruz, 2023; Lindo et al., 2020).

When it comes to the challenge of limited accessibility to WILs and EDOs of IPGTs (W2), this might stem from the cultural awareness to recognise and navigate resources to undertake such initiatives (G3). Acknowledging the perceived benefits that those exercises can enhance real-world experiences in the controlled environment, it is also noticeable to highlight the enacted approaches or pedagogical framework that fit in the purpose and characteristics of the student cohorts (Hains-Wesson et al., 2023). This persists with the perception that taking account of the student cohort’s career demands and their understanding of employability to appropriately structure the opportunities of employment and practical learning exercises (W3). Regarding the current classroom learning environment and lecturing, argued by Tomlinson (2017) that the skills garnered might not reflect the authentic skills needed in the workforce and fail to establish the transition from student identities to workplace professionals. This further proves the importance of implementing practical and hands-on experiences to develop relevant skillsets and capacities sought after by potential employers, indicating the real-world applications in professional development and personal growth of individuals. Additionally, limited WIL experiences and EDOs could lead to the direct results of lacking formal working experiences, thus constraining the development of networking, awareness & insights of the workplace, and language competencies (Gribble et al., 2017), advocating providing more opportunities to explore the unspoken workplace cultural norms for international students.

The contemporary research milieu concerning the employability of IPGTs remains somewhat indistinct and vague, especially with respect to how and when the employability shaping-up trajectories are developed. As employment patterns are difficult to measure and monitor (Jackson, 2024), more efforts would be heightened to look at the broader and more diverse stakeholders' perceptions and actions that impact the employability of IPGTs in the UK via more inclusive and smooth collaborations. While acknowledging the importance of skill enhancement through experiential learning exercises conducted on campus, it is imperative to also navigate the complexities of their international experiences off-campus, thus fostering a more dynamic trajectory of employability development.

Conclusion

This SLR seeks to understand the current conceptualisations of international student employability, focusing on the IPGT cohorts in the UK. The findings indicate that, although pursuing a British postgraduate taught degree is rewarding, the current unfavourable circumstances present significant hurdles for IPGTs, including insufficient tailored career guidance & counselling support, limited access to and opportunities for EDOs and WIL practices, and sparse culturally sensitive assistance in developing language skills and a sense of belonging. We concluded that employability research on IPGTs is still in its early stages, and the dominance of a skill-centric agenda is insufficient to address increasingly concerning issues such as escalating visa and health surcharge expenses, rising living costs, and elevated job sponsorship criteria.

In this regard, the findings suggest that it is necessary to investigate IPGTs' employability by looking into the multi-faceted domains, such as international experiences inside and outside of the university and the impact of stakeholders. In addition, ensuring the sustainability and consistency of welcoming international students necessitates concerted efforts through cross-government campaigns and a steadfast commitment to supporting more adaptable career paths and flexible employability opportunities for international students. Moreover, the scarce number of empirical studies identified through this SLR reflects that the employability of IPGTs is an under-researched area, acknowledging the economic and socio-cultural contributions that IPGTs can make. Therefore, future research should examine IPGTs' employability and international experiences within the context of their specific subjects of study and geographic disparities, leading to key discussions on how to gain a deeper understanding of these issues and devise effective strategies for improvement.

This SLR contributes to a wide array of employability-related concerns and issues encountered by IPGTs in the UK's higher education institutes. However, the authors acknowledge several limitations in this work. First, this study solely investigated empirical academic studies from selected databases (Google Scholar, Scopus, Web of Science), excluding conference proceedings, books, monographs, government reports, theoretical or conceptual-based articles, literature reviews, and grey literature. This could potentially lead to a less robust breadth and comprehensiveness of the review. Secondly, the geographical focus is limited to the UK, potentially overlooking diverse perspectives and insights on the employability of international postgraduate taught master's students, thereby limiting the generalisability of the findings on a global scale. The last limitation concerns quality assessment. As the research landscape of international student employability evolves over time, especially with the included studies encompassing widely varied methodologies, different disciplines, and geographic variations among IPGT cohorts, there is a potential impact on the reliability and validity of the review content in addressing the proposed research questions.

This SRL pioneers the initiative in examining the existing literature pertaining to the employability of IPGTs. As such, the practical implications draw upon the identification of ongoing issues and challenges faced by this cohort encompassing lack of cultural-sensible career guidance & counselling service support, equal opportunities & access to EDOs, tailored WIL experiences embedded into the programmes, and collaboration with industries to assist IPGTs' campus to workforce transition.

Additionally, this study concerns the employability-related issues of various IPGT cohorts from diverse academic disciplines and countries of origin. However, we suggest that equitable consideration and attention should be extended to STEM disciplines and lesser-explored fields to ensure a comprehensive understanding of factors shaping IPGTs' employability. Moreover, the employability of African IPGTs remains underexplored, despite the figure from Universities UK (2023a) indicating that African countries, such as Nigeria, surged to the third-largest sending country of international students to the UK in recent years. Similarly, the employability and employment prospect of Indian Subcontinent IPGTs in the UK remains under-researched, as IPGTs from this area consistently rank among the top source countries for international student recruitment (Jackson et al., 2023). This SRL also contributes to profound theoretical implications. Whilst a wide range of theories, frameworks, and models have been adopted, the overall discourse exhibits a lack of multi-stakeholder perspectives concerning how IPGTs employability journeys are shaped, with a predominant focus on students' viewpoints. Although skill-centric approaches proffer immediate insights into the direct and short-term linkage among students' employability capacities, increased needs from employers, and their employment pathways, the impact of their long-term career trajectories after graduation from British universities is less explored, suggesting the need to broaden the lens not only focus on the engagement inside of the universities but more of an integration combining their international experiences outside of the university.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

Data availability statement

The data supporting this systematic literature review were obtained from Google Scholar, Web of Science, and Scopus. While access to the full texts is subject to copyright, they can be shared by the corresponding author upon reasonable request for academic purposes.

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Appendices

Appendix 1. Internal protocol for employability of international postgraduate taught students in the UK: a systematic literature review using PRISMA

1. Review Objective: To synthesise empirical evidence on the employability of international postgraduate taught students (IPGTs) in the UK (2014–2024).

2. Eligibility Criteria

Element	Inclusion Criteria	Exclusion Criteria
Population	International postgraduate taught students (IPGTs) in UK higher education.	Non-UK contexts; (International) undergraduate/MRes/PhD students.
Intervention	Rationale of study abroad, Current challenges and opportunities, Institutional policies, pedagogical or experiential practices, or student personal strategies affecting employability.	Studies without employability focus
Outcomes	Employability skills, employment rates, career readiness, or related metrics.	Non-empirical outcomes (e.g. opinion pieces)
Study Design	Peer-reviewed empirical studies (qualitative, quantitative, mixed-methods).	Conference abstracts, PhD thesis, book chapter(s) (high quality with relevance will be considered)

3. Search Strategy

Database	Date Range	Filter Applied	Search Strings
Web of Science	2014.01.01 to 2024.12.31	Article English England	"International postgraduate student" OR "international masters student" AND ("employability") AND ("UK")
Scopus	2014–2024	Peer-reviewed Article English United Kingdom	TITLE-ABS-KEY ("international postgraduate student" OR "international masters student" OR "international student") AND TITLE-ABS-KEY ("employability" OR "employability Skills" OR "graduate employability")
Google Scholar	2014–2024	Indexed Articles English	("international postgraduate student" OR "international masters student" OR "international student") AND ("employability")

4. Screen Process

Strand(s)	Key Objective	Researcher	Action Plan and Potential Adjustments
Identification	Identify the relevant literature	Wang and Wu	Identify and export the literature lists using proposed search strings from three databases (shared OneDrive document for storage)
Screening & Inclusion	1. Remove duplicates 2. Narrow down the articles 3. Solve conflicts or disagreements	1. Wang and Wu 2. Wang, WM, Wu 3. All authors	1. Wang and Wu needs manually cross-check the samples to ensure no false exclusions (If inconsistencies are found, the team will refine the deduplication process)2. Exclusion criteria after assessing title, keywords, and abstract: direct linkage to employability, high relevance to the proposal research questions, contextual match, and empirical study3. Individual review of the final included pieces of literature with access to full texts (Final selected articles should obtain the consent to include from four authors to ensure the quality and reduce the personal bias. If consensus cannot be reached, the team will consult an external expert or revisit inclusion criteria for clarity).

5. Data Extraction, Synthesis, & Analysis

Extracted Components:year of publication, journal of publication, detailed research targets in details, location, field of study, methodology, sample size, theoretical or conceptual framework, data collection and analysis, findings and results, discussions, limitations, implications, and future studies or recommendations.

Data Synthesis & Analysis:

- Dual Independent Data Extraction:
 - Two researchers (Wang & Wu) conducted independent textual data extraction using MS Excel, wherein extract data should accurate and concise that reflected the key ideas of the extracted components.
 - Resolving discrepancies on data extraction should reach the consensus of two researchers; any conflicts will escalate to all researchers.
- Transparent Handling of Missing Data & Bias Mitigation
 - Missing data fields were explicitly marked as "blank" in Excel and excluded from thematic analysis while retaining the studies in the review.
 - The risk of bias was assessed via PRISMA 2020 principles, with potential sensitivity analysis for selected literature.

3. Thematic Analysis & Validation:

- Four authors independently applied Clarke & Braun's (2017) thematic analysis to categorise findings,
- Resolving discrepancies through consensus in the meetings (TBC)
- Outcomes need to be synthesised qualitatively and allocated into three proposed research questions transparently (no effect measures).

6. Data Analysis

Thematic analysis will be conducted using the framework by Clarke and Braun (2017). To ensure rigour, themes will be derived independently, followed by collaborative discussions to resolve discrepancies and finalise emerging themes (Wang, Wu, WM, & Huang).

7. Findings

RQ	Aim	Researcher	Predicted Outcomes
RQ1	Understanding of employability of IPGTs	All authors	Identified the key array of factors or dimensions of the existing refinement and understanding of IPGTs' employability.
RQ2	Main Challenges	All authors	Identified the recurring challenges that IPGTs encounter, especially when it comes to their employability development.
RQ3	How to better support IPGTs' employability	All authors	Propose evidence-based support strategies or actionable recommendations from the selected literature.

8. Protocol Limitations & Key Recommendations

1. Subjectivity in Screening & Extraction:

- Risk: Inconsistent application of inclusion criteria or data extraction.
- Solution: Strictly adhere to the utilisation of the predefined coding rules with third-reviewer validation.

2. Data Coding Discrepancies & Bias:

- Risk: Delays from emerged theme disputes or overrepresented findings due to the independent analysis
- Solution: Set clear consensus thresholds and document outlier themes for transparency.

3. Retrospective Protocol Development:

- Risk: This protocol was developed retrospectively due to the exploratory nature of the review and revision process, which may introduce inconsistencies in the initial screening or extraction.
- All methodological decisions were documented iteratively during the review process to ensure transparency and alignment with PRISMA 2020 guidelines as well as the PRISMA 2020 checklist.

Appendix 2 PRISMA 2020 Checklist

Section (Topic)	Item	Checklist Item	Reported Location
Title			
Abstract	1	Identify the report as a systematic review.	Title
Abstract	2a	Identify the report as a systematic review.	Abstract
	2b	Provide an explicit statement of the main objective(s) or question(s) the review addresses.	Abstract
	2c	Specify the inclusion and exclusion criteria for the review.	Abstract
	2d	Specify the information sources (e.g. databases, registers) used to identify studies and the date when each was last searched.	Abstract
	2e	Specify the methods used to assess the risk of bias in the included studies.	Abstract
	2f	Specify the methods used to present and synthesise results.	Abstract
	2g	Give the total number of included studies and participants and summarise relevant characteristics of studies.	Abstract
	2h	Present results for main outcomes, preferably indicating the number of included studies and participants for each. If meta-analysis was done, report the summary estimate and confidence/credible interval. If comparing groups, indicate the direction of the effect (i.e. which group is favoured).	Abstract
	2i	Provide a brief summary of the limitations of the evidence included in the review (e.g. study risk of bias, inconsistency and imprecision).	Abstract
	2j	Provide a general interpretation of the results and important implications.	Abstract

(Continued)

Continued.

Section (Topic)	Item	Checklist Item	Reported Location
Introduction			
Rationale	3	Describe the rationale for the review in the context of existing knowledge.	Introduction, 2.1, & 2.2
Objectives	4	Provide an explicit statement of the objective(s) or question(s) the review addresses.	Introduction
Methods			
Eligibility Criteria	5	Specify the inclusion and exclusion criteria for the review and how studies were grouped for the syntheses.	3.2
Information Sources	6	Specify all databases, registers, websites, organisations, reference lists and other sources searched or consulted to identify studies. Specify the date when each source was last searched or consulted.	3.1
Search Strategy	7	Present the full search strategies for all databases, registers and websites, including any filters and limits used.	3.1 & Appendix 1
Selection Process	8	Specify the methods used to decide whether a study met the inclusion criteria of the review, including how many reviewers screened each record and each report retrieved, whether they worked independently, and if applicable, details of automation tools used in the process.	3.3 & Figure 1
Data Collection Process	9	Specify the methods used to collect data from reports, including how many reviewers collected data from each report, whether they worked independently, any processes for obtaining or confirming data from study investigators, and if applicable, details of automation tools used in the process.	3.3 & 3.4
Data Items	10a	List and define all outcomes for which data were sought. Specify whether all results that were compatible with each outcome domain in each study were sought (e.g. for all measures, time points, analyses), and if not, the methods used to decide which results to collect.	3.3 & 3.4
	10b	List and define all other variables for which data were sought (e.g. participant and intervention characteristics, funding sources). Describe any assumptions made about any missing or unclear information.	3.3 & 3.4
Study Risk of Bias Assessment	11	Specify the methods used to assess risk of bias in the included studies, including details of the tool(s) used, how many reviewers assessed each study and whether they worked independently, and if applicable, details of automation tools used in the process.	3.3 & 3.4
Effect Measures	12	Specify for each outcome the effect measure(s) (e.g. risk ratio, mean difference) used in the synthesis or presentation of results.	3.4
Synthesis Methods	13a	Describe the processes used to decide which studies were eligible for each synthesis (e.g. tabulating the study intervention characteristics and comparing against the planned groups for each synthesis).	3.4
	13b	Describe any methods required to prepare the data for presentation or synthesis, such as handling of missing summary statistics or data conversions.	3.4
	13c	Describe any methods used to tabulate or visually display the results of individual studies and syntheses.	3.4 & 4.1
	13d	Describe any methods used to synthesise results and provide a rationale for the choice(s). If meta-analysis was performed, describe the model(s), method(s) to identify the presence and extent of statistical heterogeneity, and software package(s) used.	3.4
	13e	Describe any methods used to explore possible causes of heterogeneity among study results (e.g. subgroup analysis, meta-regression).	3.4
	13f	Describe any sensitivity analyses conducted to assess the robustness of the synthesised results.	3.2
Reporting Bias Assessment	14	Describe any methods used to assess the risk of bias due to missing results in a synthesis (arising from reporting biases).	3.3, 3.4, & 3.5
Certainty Assessment	15	Describe any methods used to assess certainty (or confidence) in the body of evidence for an outcome.	3.5
Results			
Study Selection	16a		Figure 1 & 4.1

(Continued)

Continued.

Section (Topic)	Item	Checklist Item	Reported Location
Study Characteristics		Describe the results of the search and selection process, from the number of records identified in the search to the number of studies included in the review, ideally using a flow diagram.	
	16b	Cite studies that might appear to meet the inclusion criteria, but which were excluded, and explain why they were excluded.	3.3
	17	Cite each included study and present its characteristics.	4.1.1, 4.1.2, 4.1.3, & 4.1.4
Risk of Bias in Studies	18	Present assessments of risk of bias for each included study.	3.3
Results of Individual Studies	19	For all outcomes, present, for each study: (a) summary statistics for each group (where appropriate) and (b) an effect estimates and its precision (e.g. confidence/credible interval), ideally using structured tables or plots.	4.1 & 4.2
Results of Syntheses	20a	For each synthesis, briefly summarise the characteristics and risk of bias among contributing studies.	3.4
	20b	Present results of all statistical syntheses conducted. If meta-analysis was done, present for each the summary estimate and its precision (e.g. confidence/credible interval) and measures of statistical heterogeneity. If comparing groups, describe the direction of the effect.	4.2.1, 4.2.2, & 4.2.3
	20c	Present results of all investigations of possible causes of heterogeneity among study results.	3.4
	20d	Present results of all sensitivity analyses conducted to assess the robustness of the synthesised results.	3.3 & 3.4
Reporting Biases	21	Present assessments of risk of bias due to missing results (arising from reporting biases) for each synthesis assessed.	3.3
Discussion			
Discussion	23a	Provide a general interpretation of the results in the context of other evidence.	4.1
	23b	Discuss any limitations of the evidence included in the review.	3.5 & Conclusion
	23c	Discuss any limitations of the review processes used.	3.5
	23d	Discuss implications of the results for practice, policy, and future research.	Conclusion
Other Information			
Registration and Protocol	24a	Provide registration information for the review, including register name and registration number, or state that the review was not registered.	3.5
	24b	Indicate where the review protocol can be accessed, or state that a protocol was not prepared.	Appendix 1
	24c	Describe and explain any amendments to the information provided at registration or in the protocol.	Appendix 1
Support	25	Describe sources of financial or non-financial support for the review and the role of the funders or sponsors in the review.	Disclosure Statement
Competing Interests	26	Declare any competing interests of the review authors.	Disclosure Statement
Availability of Data, Code, & Other Materials	27	Report which of the following are publicly available and where they can be found: template data collection forms; data extracted from included studies; data used for all analyses; analytic code; any other materials used in the review.	Data Availability Statement